

Reading

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The Teacher Who Never Gave Up

Before you read

- Look at the title. What kind of life story do you expect to read?
- Have you ever heard of someone who overcame great hardship to succeed?

By the time Elif turned forty, she had already achieved something that few people from her small village had ever managed: she had become the headteacher of the region's largest school. But her path there had not been easy.

Elif had grown up in a mountain village where, at the time, few girls had continued their education beyond primary school. Her parents had never gone to secondary school themselves, but they had always believed that education could change their daughter's future. By the time she was twelve, Elif had already decided that she wanted to become a teacher, even though nobody in her family had ever worked in education before.

After she had finished secondary school in the nearest town, she had to travel two hours by bus every day to attend university. She later said that by the time she graduated, she had missed countless family events and had faced financial hardship that had tested her more than once. Still, she had never given up on her goal.

Her first teaching post had been in a small rural school that had not had enough books or equipment. Elif had spent her own savings buying materials for her students. Within a few years, word of her dedication had spread, and by the time a position opened at the regional school, she had already built a reputation as one of the most resilient teachers in the area.

Today, when Elif looks back, she says that everything she had gone through had shaped the teacher she eventually became. Her story has become an inspiration for many young people in her village who now believe that, like her, they too can overcome hardship and reach their own milestones.

1. What had Elif achieved by the time she turned forty?
 - a. She had opened her own school.
 - b. She had become the headteacher of the region's largest school.
 - c. She had written a book about education.
 - d. She had moved to a different country.
2. Elif's parents had studied at secondary school themselves. — *True / False*
3. By the time she was twelve, Elif had already _____ that she wanted to become a teacher.
4. What had Elif done with her own savings?
 - a. She had bought a house.
 - b. She had paid for her university fees.
 - c. She had bought materials for her students.
 - d. She had donated them to her village.

5. Explain in your own words why Elif's journey to becoming a teacher had not been easy. (*Elif's journey had not been easy because...*)

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After you read

- Do you know anyone whose life story resembles Elif's? What made them resilient?
- What milestone would you like to have achieved by the time you are forty?

A Return to the Abandoned House

Before you read

- Predict: why might someone want to return to a place they lived in as a child?
- What feelings do old, abandoned places often create?

When Kerem parked his car in front of the old house, he felt a wave of nostalgia. He had not visited the place since his family had relocated to the city twenty years earlier, and by the time he got out of the car, memories he had almost forgotten had already begun to return.

The house looked very different from how he remembered it. The garden his grandfather had once carefully looked after had become overgrown, and the walls, which had been painted a bright blue when he was a child, were now faded and cracked. Someone had clearly abandoned the property years before, and nature had slowly taken it back.

Kerem walked through what had once been the kitchen. He recalled that his grandmother had always been cooking something there, and the smell of fresh bread had filled the whole house every morning. He remembered that, before he had even woken up, she had usually already prepared breakfast for the whole family.

In the corner of the main room, Kerem found an old wooden chest that his family had left behind when they had moved. Inside, he discovered photographs that had faded over the decades, along with a notebook his grandfather had written in. As he read the pages, he realised how much of his family's history he had never known before that moment.

Kerem left the house that afternoon feeling that, although the building had changed completely, the memories it held had not faded at all. He decided that he would come back again soon, this time bringing his own children so they could learn about the place their family had once called home.

1. How long had it been since Kerem had visited the house?

- a. Ten years
- b. Fifteen years
- c. Twenty years
- d. Thirty years

2. The garden had been well cared for by the time Kerem returned. — *True / False*

3. Before Kerem had even woken up, his grandmother had usually already _____ breakfast.

4. What did Kerem find in the old wooden chest?

- a. Old clothes and toys
- b. Photographs and a notebook
- c. Money and jewellery
- d. Letters and a map

5. In your own words, explain what Kerem decided to do at the end of the story and why. (*At the end, Kerem decided...*)

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After you read

- Have you ever returned to a place from your childhood? What had changed?
- Why do you think old family objects, like photographs or notebooks, matter to people?